

Country Profile: Portugal

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 3
- Plurality religion: Roman Catholicism
- Official language: Portuguese
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Portuguese

Historical Background

Portugal was one of the first global colonial powers during the 15th and 16th centuries. In 1910, the ruling monarchy was overthrown, giving way to the First Portuguese Republic.¹ A military coup in 1926 led to the authoritarian Estado Novo regime under António de Oliveira Salazar. The regime collapsed in 1974 with the Carnation Revolution, which also triggered rapid decolonization. Within two years, following protracted anti-colonial wars, Portugal granted independence to its five African colonies: Angola, Mozambique, Guinea-Bissau, Cape Verde, and São Tome and Príncipe. Portugal adopted a democratic constitution in 1976 and is now a unitary parliamentary republic. It joined the European Economic Community (now the European Union) in 1986.

Groups

- **Portuguese** are the core group of Portugal, constituting 93% of the population.² They speak Portuguese, the official language of the country. The vast majority follow Roman Catholicism, with a very small minority adhering to Evangelical churches.³
- **Azoreans/Madeirans** comprise a nested group, making up 6% of the population.⁴ The group consists of two subgroups from the Portuguese archipelagos: the **Azoreans**, from the Azores, and the **Madeirans**, from Madeira. Both Azoreans and

¹ Britannica, n.d.

² Pordata, 2023a.

³ Joshua Project, 2025; The Association of Religion Data Archives, n.d.

⁴ Pordata, 2023a.

Madeirans speak Portuguese, and the vast majority of both follow Roman Catholicism.⁵ The Azoreans began pressing for self-determination in 1975 with the formation of the Front for the Liberation of the Azores, staging sporadic separatist demonstrations that continued until 1990.⁶ Similarly, in Madeira, demands for self-rule emerged between 1974 and 2000, marked by the establishment of the Madeira Archipelago Liberation Front.⁷

- **Afro-Portuguese** are a nested racialized group with a colonial history made up of **Cape Verdeans, Angolans, and Mozambicans**. Together, they constitute around 1% of the population.⁸ Afro-Portuguese began arriving in notable numbers in 1975 following the independence of Portuguese colonies and the outbreak of civil wars in countries like Angola (until 2002) and Mozambique (until 1992). They also arrived in Portugal as labor migrants.⁹ Cape Verdeans speak Kabuverdianu, and the vast majority adhere to Roman Catholicism. Angolans speak Portuguese, and the majority are Roman Catholic, with about a quarter following Protestantism.¹⁰ Mozambicans speak Portuguese and are religiously diverse, with over a third following Roman Catholicism, just under one-third following Sunni Islam, and less than one-third following Protestantism.¹¹ Their religious beliefs are mostly the result of colonial-era conversion from traditional animist beliefs.¹² Most Afro-Portuguese have historically been concentrated in the urban areas surrounding Lisbon.¹³

State Profile

Official Language

The official language of Portugal is Portuguese, as stated in Article 11.3 of the 1976 Constitution.¹⁴

⁵ Joshua Project, 2025.

⁶ Sambanis et al., 2018.

⁷ Sambanis et al., 2018.

⁸ Pordata, 2023b.

⁹ Augusto et al., 2022; Castelo, 2009.

¹⁰ Eberhard et al., 2025; The Association of Religion Data Archives, n.d.

¹¹ Eberhard et al., 2025; The Association of Religion Data Archives, n.d.

¹² Neves, 2007.

¹³ Machado, 2009.

¹⁴ Constitution of the Portuguese Republic, 1976.

Official Religion

There is no official religion of Portugal; the separation of the church and state is stipulated in Article 41 of the 1976 Constitution. This Article also recognizes freedom of conscience, religion, and worship.¹⁵ Its predecessor in 1933 also recognized the separation of church and state in Article 46.¹⁶

Education Policies

The education system in Portugal is overseen by the Ministry of Education. Education is compulsory for a period of 12 years, from the ages of 6 to 18. Students begin with six years of primary education (*ensino básico*) from grades 1 to 6. Then, there is lower secondary school, from grades 7 to 9. At grade 9, students choose between academic or vocational tracks for upper secondary education (grades 10–12).¹⁷ **Private schools** have operated in the country for the whole study period. As per the Base Law of Private Education from 1949, it was mandatory for **private schools** to impart Roman Catholic teachings. This lasted until 1975 and the end of the Estado Novo. Since the democratic transition in 1976, the teaching of any religion has been permitted.¹⁸

Language Education Policies

While National Education Laws do not explicitly state it, **Portuguese** was the only language of instruction in public schools in Portugal throughout the study period. The 1986 Education Act (revised in 2005) defines the system's objective as the “development of knowledge and appreciation for Portuguese language and culture” (Article 7).¹⁹ Earlier legal frameworks, such as the 1952 Law on Popular Education and the 1933 Constitution, similarly made no mention of language, implicitly affirming Portuguese as the only language of instruction.²⁰ There are no legal restrictions on the language of instruction, and private schools offer education in other languages, such as **English, French, and German**. **Kabuverdianu** is neither used as a language of instruction nor offered as a subject in public schools.²¹

¹⁵ Constitution of Portugal, 1976.

¹⁶ Political Constitution of the Portuguese Republic, 1933.

¹⁷ Eurydice, n.d.; Scholaro, n.d.

¹⁸ Pintassilgo, 2010; Eurydice, n.d.

¹⁹ Lei n.º 46/86, 1986; Eurydice, n.d.

²⁰ Eurydice, n.d.

²¹ Santa-Clara, 2014.

Religious Education Policies

During the Estado Novo dictatorship, it was mandatory for both public and private schools in Portugal to teach Roman Catholicism. In public schools, the instruction of **Roman Catholicism** was mandatory until 1973. Following the adoption of a democratic constitution in 1976, religious instruction became optional, and any religion could be taught.²² Although the democratic Constitution adopted in 1976 formally guaranteed freedom of religion, the 1940 Concordat between Portugal and the Vatican remained in force, continuing to give privileged status to Catholicism in the education system. Under this agreement, the state was financially responsible for ensuring the presence of Catholic instruction in schools, which delayed the integration of other religious teachings. In 2001, the Law on Religious Freedom passed, affirming that religious education is the responsibility of each religious community. While optional “religion and ethics” classes—taught by lay instructors—remained available in public schools, the new framework allowed other religious groups, such as Protestant and Sunni Muslim communities, to offer optional religious education.²³ These classes could be provided if at least 10 students enrolled and the community supplied a qualified teacher.²⁴

Constitutions and Laws

Portugal has had two major constitutional frameworks in force between 1945 and 2020. The first, the 1933 Constitution, does not designate an official language, nor does it mention any specific group. Article 45 affirms freedom of worship: “The public and private practice of any religion is free.” Article 46 grants privileged status to the Catholic Church, while affirming the separation of church and state: “The State shall maintain the regime of separation in relation to the Catholic Church and any other religion practiced within Portuguese territory, and diplomatic relations between the Holy See and Portugal.”²⁵

The 1976 Constitution was adopted following the Carnation Revolution. Its Preamble affirms the commitment to a “democratic state based on the rule of law”. It also makes explicit mention of the “Portuguese” people. Article 11.3 explicitly designates Portuguese as the official language. Religious freedom is protected under Article 41, which establishes freedom of conscience, religion, and worship. Article 41.4 guarantees the

²² Caetano, 2010.

²³ Law of the Portuguese Republic on Religious Freedom, 2001.

²⁴ Mapil, 2014.

²⁵ Political Constitution of the Portuguese Republic, 1933.

separation of church and state. Unlike its predecessor, this constitution contains no references to a specific religion. This constitution also grants increased autonomy to the Azores and Madeira in Article 6.2: “The Azores and Madeira archipelagos shall be autonomous regions with their own political and administrative statutes and self-government institutions.”²⁶

Citizenship Laws

Portugal has traditionally favored an unconditional birthright *jus soli* framework, which dates back to the 17th century and was continued by the 1959 Nationality Act. However, the 1981 Nationality Act introduced a model centered on *jus sanguinis*.²⁷ Under this law, citizenship was primarily granted by descent, requiring individuals born in Portugal to foreign parents to meet additional criteria for naturalization.²⁸ Between 1981 and 2006, birth in Portugal alone was insufficient to obtain citizenship unless the parents were stateless or of unknown nationality.²⁹

The 2006 Amendment retained the emphasis on *jus sanguinis* but expanded and clarified access to citizenship through *jus soli* and naturalization. Notably, it introduced new modes of acquisition for second-generation immigrants: children born in Portugal to foreign parents could acquire nationality if one parent had resided legally in the country for at least five years at the time of birth. The reform also lowered the general residence requirement for naturalization from 10 to six years and introduced a five-year rule for those born and raised in Portugal.³⁰

Portugal's naturalization framework has privileged applicants from Lusophone (Portuguese-speaking) countries. Under the 1994 nationality law, citizens of Portuguese-speaking countries needed only six years of legal residence to qualify for naturalization, compared to 10 years for others.³¹ This provision was removed in the 2006 Nationality Law, which established a uniform five-year residency requirement for all applicants regardless of origin. However, the 2006 reform introduced a new language proficiency requirement: while all applicants must demonstrate sufficient knowledge of Portuguese, individuals from Lusophone countries are presumed to meet this criterion automatically,

²⁶ Constitution of the Portuguese Republic, 1976.

²⁷ Law No. 37/81, 1981.

²⁸ Baganha and Urbano de Sousa, 2006; Gil and Piçarra, 2020.

²⁹ Gil & Piçarra, 2020.

³⁰ Decree-Law No. 237-A/2006, 2006; Gil & Piçarra, 2020.

³¹ Gil and Piçarra, 2020.

whereas others must pass a certified language test.³² Portugal has not excluded any group from accessing national citizenship.

National Anthem(s)

Portugal's national anthem, *A Portuguesa* ("The Portuguese"), was composed in 1890 as a patriotic response to the British ultimatum demanding Portuguese withdrawal from African territories. It became a popular protest song against the monarchy and was formally adopted as the national anthem following the establishment of the republic in 1910. The anthem is structured around themes of military resistance, national pride, and historical remembrance. It opens with the invocation "Heroes of the sea, noble race," evoking the legacy of Portuguese explorers and national forefathers. The chorus repeatedly calls citizens "To arms, to arms / On land and sea!" and urges them to "march against the enemy guns," embedding explicit military references. Martyrdom is indirectly suggested through the anthem's framing of national revival as a response to insult and humiliation—echoes of the colonial crisis that inspired its creation. References to the national territory appear in lines such as "Your happy land is kissed / By the Ocean," while heroic struggle is recalled in the assertion that Portugal's "conquering arm / Has given new worlds to the world." *A Portuguesa* is a fervent call to patriotic defense, linking past glories and territorial pride with military vigilance and collective dignity.³³

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³² Gil and Piçarra, 2020.

³³ Nationalanthems.info, n.d.

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